

STRUCTURED INTERVENTION & RAPPORT BUILDING CHECKLIST

A GUIDE FOR SLPs, BCBAs, AND SPECIAL EDUCATORS

From Play to Purpose: The 6-Phase Rapport-Building Guide for Working with Autistic Learners. This step-by-step checklist is designed for any interventionist working with a wide range of learner profiles, including those on the autism spectrum disorder (ASD). The goal of this structured intervention is to help learners transition from playtime to structured instruction by first building trust (rapport) and communication, and then gradually introducing instructional demands (instructional fading).

RULE OF THUMB

1. Advance Slowly: Only move to the next PHASE when the learner has had three consecutive sessions with minimal to no disruptive behaviors at the current phase.
2. No Forcing: Never use physical force to make the learner stay at the table or complete a task. Always respect learner assent.
3. Follow their Interests: Always use the learner's highly preferred toys, activities, sensory needs, or movements to build engagement.

Phase 1. Establish You = Fun

Phase 2. Establish the Table = Fun

Phase 3. "Connection" to "Communication"

Phase 4. Let it go!

Phase 5. Ease in the work

Phase 6. Structured learning begins

PHASE 1. ESTABLISH YOU = FUN (RAPPORT BUILDING/PAIRING)

The goal here is simply to show the learner that you are a source of good things, with absolutely no pressure to work or communicate.

- ☐ **Free Access of items through YOU. Approach the child with their highly preferred items and play with them wherever they are in the room. Deliver the item to the child immediately when the learner indicates interest (e.g., reaching for it).**

- ☐ Do not give any instructions or demands. The learner does not have to speak or communicate to obtain the item. Give freely—the only requirement is that the item comes from YOU.
- ☐ Offer new items frequently (e.g., every 30 seconds) or whenever the child shows interest.

PHASE 2 ESTABLISH THE TABLE = FUN (LOCATION FADING)

The goal here is to get the learner used to being at the learning table without actually doing any “work” yet.

- ☐ **Free Access at the Table (at least 3 preferred items). The teacher sits at the learning table with the preferred items.**
- ☐ Do not give any instructions.
- ☐ Allow the learner to play freely as long as they come over to the table. If they wish to leave the table, let them walk freely. *However, all fun items or introduction of new items which the child shows interest in remain at the table.*
- ☐ **Play at the Table. Continue to engage with the learner using the fun items, but now require them to stand/sit by the table to access them. Your 1st FIRST/THEN rule: first come to the table, then play.**
- ☐ You can use gentle guidance to help them sit, but do not force them. Still no academic demands are placed.

PHASE 3. “CONNECTION” TO “COMMUNICATION” (TEACHING TO REQUEST)

The goal here is to build the learner’s motivation to actively request preferred items from you.

- ☐ **The First Demand = Request. Keep playing at the table. Wait for the learner to show interest in an item (e.g., reaching for it).**
- ☐ Once you notice the learner’s “motivation” of getting the item from you, provide the expected response to request the item (e.g., gestures, AAC, sounds, word approximations, words, phrases). Wait for 3 seconds. If the learner responds by following the model, deliver the item immediately. If the learner does not respond, provide the model once more and deliver the item.

Repeat the last step until the learner’s communicative response is consistent. Learners learn the only way to get access to what they want is to *communicate* with you.

PHASE 4. LET IT GO! (TEACHING TO RELINQUISH)

The goal here is to teach the essential skill of temporarily relinquishing a preferred item.

- ☐ For activities the learner is highly engaged in and would not naturally stop (e.g., magnet tiles, fidget toys), consider setting a timer or giving a verbal reminder before taking the item away (priming).

- ❑ **When the timer goes off or the agreed interval has lapsed, provide a clearly designated container or area for the item (e.g., a storage bin). Give a clear instruction to the learner: “Put the [item] in the bin.”**
- ❑ After the learner relinquishes the preferred item, a natural opportunity arises for them to request it again. Prompt the learner’s requesting response as needed to help them regain access to the item.

Repeat the last two steps until the learner is able to relinquish the item consistently.

PHASE 5. EASE IN THE WORK (INSTRUCTIONAL FADING)

The goal here is to introduce brief, low-effort instructions within a fun and supportive environment.

- ❑ **Fade in your “first/then” rule—the next time your learner requests, you can say “Yes, you can have the [item]; first, let’s do [demand].”** Start with something simple and developmentally appropriate (e.g. imitation with objects/imitating play schemes, simple listener/receptive task). See the cheat sheet for 20 easy first demands. Make sure to start with something easy to do and appropriate for the learner’s level.
- ❑ Slight Increase in Demands. Engage with the preferred items together. Present **one demand per minute** when they show interest in an item.
- ❑ Slight Increase in Demands. Engage with the preferred items together. Present **one demand every 30 seconds** when they show interest in a toy.
- ❑ Two Quick Demands. Present **two demands every 30 seconds** following an indication of interest. Always provide immediate access to the fun activity right after they complete the tasks.
- ❑ Shortening the Play Interval. Present **two or three demands every 15 seconds**.

Remember: Stay attuned to your learner’s interest and engagement. If they slow down or show signs of refusal, extend the play period before reintroducing demands. Step back to the previous successful phase to rebuild tolerance before progressing. Continue to keep preferred items at the table or reserve them exclusively for the work phase.

PHASE 6. STRUCTURED LEARNING BEGINS (DYNAMIC TEACHING)

The goal is to establish an instruction or therapy session in which the learner remains in an active learning area (seating optional), stays engaged, and is actively learning.

- ❑ Active Teaching Phase. **Present one to five demands every 15 to 30 seconds.** Vary the pacing and keep it natural so the learner stays engaged in a dynamic learning session without feeling the structure.
- ❑ To put it in ratio terms: start with 80% fun/20% work ratio, then move onto 60/40, 50/50, 40/60, and ultimately 20% fun/80% work.

*****Remember: Be dynamic and flexible. Quality over quantity!**

FROM PLAY TO PURPOSE: 20 EASY "FIRST DEMANDS" CHEAT SHEET

Mix and match these! Deliver each instruction clearly. If the learner does not respond within 3 seconds, gently provide a physical prompt, then immediately return their preferred item the moment they complete the action.

Fun & Social (High Success Rate)

These are great because they often feel like an extension of play.

"Give me a high five!" (Hold your hand up)

"Fist bump!" (Hold your fist out)

"Knock on the table." (Demonstrate by knocking twice)

"Wave hello!" (Wave your hand)

"Tickle my hand." (Hold your hand out palm up)

Gross Motor / Body Parts (Simon Says Style)

Say "Do this" and model the action, or simply give the verbal instruction if they know it well.

6. "Touch your nose."

7. "Clap your hands."

8. "Tap your head."

9. "Stomp your feet."

10. "Put your hands up!" (Raise your arms in the air)

11. "Tap the desk." (Tap the desk with a flat palm)

Play-Based & Object Manipulation

Use the items already on the table to your advantage. These barely feel like work!

12. "Put it in." (Hold out a bucket or bin and have them drop a block/toy inside)

13. "Push the button." (On a cause-and-effect toy they are playing with)

14. "Hand me the [item]." (Ask for a piece of the toy they aren't currently holding)

15. "Roll the car." (Have them push a toy car one inch toward you)

16. "Stack this." (Hand them one block to put on top of another)

Simple Receptive (Pointing & Touching)

Very low physical effort for the learner.

17. "Touch the paper." (Have a piece of colored paper on the desk)

18. "Point to the light/door/window." (Pick something obvious in the room)

19. "Touch my elbow." (Point to your own elbow)

20. "Give it to me." (Ask them to hand you the toy they are holding—Warning: Only use this one if you are 100% sure they will easily give it up, otherwise it can trigger a struggle!)

References:

- Cariveau, T., Shillingsburg, M. A., Alamoudi, A., Thompson, T., Bartlett, B., Gillespie, S., & Scahill, L. (2020). A structured intervention to increase response allocation to instructional settings for children with autism spectrum disorder. *Journal of Behavioral Education*, 29(4), 699–716.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/s10864-019-09340-x>.
- Shillingsburg, M. A., Hansen, B., & Wright, M. (2019). Rapport-building and instructional fading prior to discrete-trial instruction: Moving from child-led play to intensive teaching. *Behavior Modification*, 43(2), 288–306. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0145445517751436>.

